Bukas-Loob sa Diyos
Covenant Community - Archdiocese of NewArk

Bitter Root
Hearts of Stone
Inner Vows

Prayer Healing Seminar I

Scripture Foundation
Bitter Root

HEB 12:15 "SEE TO IT THAT NO ONE BE DEPRIVED OF THE GRACE OF GOD, THAT NO BITTER ROOT SPRING UP AND CAUSE TROUBLE, THROUGH WHICH MANY BECOME DEFILED."

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THE LAW OF JUDGMENT APPLIES NOT ONLY TO OUR CONSCIOUS ACTIONS, KNOWN AND PERFORMED OUTWARDLY, BUT ALSO TO WHAT IS LODGED IN OUR HEARTS, RESERVED, UNKNOWN AND UNEXPRESSED. ONCE FORMED, JUDGMENTS BRING RESULTS. BITTER ROOTS NOT BROUGHT TO THE CROSS DEFILE.

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A ROOT IS A HIDDEN, AN UNDERGROUND STRUCTURE THAT PROVIDES NOURISHMENT.

FOR US, "ROOTS" ARE HABITUAL WAYS WE DRINK NURTURE FROM GOD, OTHERS, NATURE AND OURSELVES. OUR ROOTS LIE BENEATH THE SURFACE, USUALLY HIDDEN TO THE ADULT MIND.

Bitter Root

- IF WE HAVE BITTER ROOTS, WE DRINK HARM TO OURSELVES.
- IF WE ARE ROOTED IN CHRIST, WE DRINK NOURISHMENT FROM GOD AND HIS CREATION

WHAT ARE BITTER ROOTS OR BITTER ROOT JUDGMENTS?

- SINFUL REACTIONS TO HURT
- CRITICAL, CONDEMNING JUDGMENTS OF PEOPLE
- REFUSAL OR INABILITY TO FORGIVE SOMEONE
- THEY HAVE THE POWER TO DEFILE MANY, INCLUDING OURSELVES, CAUSING US TO DRINK "POISON" INSTEAD OF NOURISHMENT.
- THEY OPERATE ACCORDING TO THE UNCHANGEABLE LAW OF SOWING AND REAPING, WHICH CAUSES US TO REAP IN KIND WHAT WE HAVE SOWN. (Galatians 6:7)

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BITTER ROOTS ARE NOT:

- THE HURTFUL OR TERRIBLE THINGS THAT HAPPEN TO US, NOR THE SINS OF THOSE WHO HAVE WRONGED US; THEY ARE OUR SINS.
- POWERFUL ENOUGH TO OVERCOME THE FREE WILL OF ANOTHER, BUT THEY DO DEFILE.

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BITTER ROOTS INFECT THE MIND WITH EXPECTANCIES.

- PSYCHOLOGICAL PRACTICES IN OUR NATURE
- HABITS OF SELF-FULFILLING PROPHECY, BY WHICH WE PUSH PEOPLE TO FULFILL OUR PICTURE OF THE WAY THINGS SHOULD GO.

Bitter Root Expectation
Example

A man brought up by a critical mother:
- feels wounded and rejected, he protects his heart by withdrawing
- his experiences with his mother form his picture of a "woman"
- when he marries, he expects criticism and projects his expectancies onto his wife
- he keeps her distant to protect himself
- lonely, she appeals to him to share with her – he interprets this as criticism
- when she becomes openly critical of his treatment of her, he doesn't see his part in pushing her to fulfill that expectation

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WHERE DO WE FIND JUDGMENTS AND EXPECTANCIES?

- OUR RELATIONSHIP WITH OUR PARENTS AND THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN OUR PARENTS
- PRIMARY PEOPLE DURING OUR FOUNDATION YEARS – GRANDPARENTS, BABYSITTERS, PRIMARY SCHOOL TEACHERS

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FOUR BASIC LAWS THAT GOVERN OUR RELATIONSHIPS: SUMMARY

1)	Deut. 5: 16	Law of Honoring & Dishonoring
2)	Matt. 7: 1-2	Law of Judging & Receiving
3)	Gal. 6: 7-8	Law of Sowing & Reaping
4)	Romans 2:1	Law of becoming what we judge

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WE ARE ACCOUNTABLE FOR OUR SINFUL REACTIONS AND OUR JUDGMENTS, NO MATTER WHAT HAPPENED TO US.

- WE ARE GUILTY, BUT NOT CONDEMNED.
- GUILT IS THE FRIEND, WHICH BRINGS US TO THE CROSS, TO HEALING AND TRANSFORMATION

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MAXIM FOR ALL OF US:

If you have the fruit, you have the root.

Counselors must be aware that bitter root judgments and expectancies are so common that every counselor should check for them as routinely as a doctor checks blood pressure and temperature.

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HEALING FOR BITTER ROOTS:
SACRAMENT OF RECONCILIATION

A. RECOGNITION - to see the patterns and discuss how they are affecting our lives and those of others.
B. CONFESSION – allows us to be fully known before God, in our brokenness and sin, so that He can heal and change us.
C. REPENTANCE – Choosing change, determining to stop patterns by bringing judgments and expectancies to death on the cross in prayer.

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HEALING FOR BITTER ROOTS

D. PRAYER – be specific, focused and Spirit-led
   1. Prayers for forgiveness
      - Counselee prays aloud:
      "*I forgive you Dad….*
      Lord, I forgive Dad for ……."
      Then, "*Lord, forgive me for judging/resenting/hating Dad. And forgive me for perpetuating those attitudes in my present relationships.*"

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HEALING FOR BITTER ROOTS

2. Prayers of death
– to break down structures of judgment and expectancies, habits, attitudes, reflexes, by taking them to the Cross of Christ.

1 Peter 2:24 *"He himself bore our sins in His body upon the cross, so that, free from sin, we might live for righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed."*

"*Lord, bring those practices to death by the power of Your cross.*"

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HEALING FOR BITTER ROOTS

3. Prayers of resurrection and life

"*Lord, restore*….. (be specific)"

"*Lord, reverse the old pattern and cause its glorious opposite to happen"*

"*Lord, restore to new life; build in me new ways*." (to impart a new expectancy)

"*.. that I may know Him, and the power of His resurrection*

Philippians 3:10-15

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HEALING FOR BITTER ROOTS

E. RESTITUTION -

This may be necessary to restore trust in relationships and build new structures in a person's life.

F. HEALING CONTINUES AS THE COUNSELEE CONTINUES

- in fellowship, and in counseling to discover branch roots
- in prayer as an ongoing discipline
  - to see and bring to death habitual ways of thinking, feeling and behaving
  - to bring to life the nature of Christ

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HEALING FOR BITTER ROOTS

G. HEALING IS ACCOMPLISHED

- when gratitude is full, not forced
- when transformation has turned the "mess" into glory of God

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Summary

God has written balance and justice into the universe. When counselees come with marriage problems, it is almost 50-50.

A wife will most likely do to her husband that for which he bitterly judged his mother, and the wife will likely reap through her husband the very same thing for which she judged her father.

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Summary

It is a painful process when a couple begins to discover hidden things about one another. But it is God's design and as we take our sins to the cross, we can enter into a blessed relationship with our spouse and other people, fulfilling God's will for transformation in our lives.

Scripture Foundation
Hearts of Stone

- Ezekiel 11:19b-20: "I will remove the hearts of stone, and give them hearts of flesh, so that they walk according to my statutes, taking care to keep my ordinances. Thus they will be my people and I will be their God."

Heart of Stone
The Heart

- Biblical meaning of the heart
  - CCC 2563: our hidden center
  - CCC 2562: the source of prayer
  - CCC 2517: seat of our moral personality
- What is a hardened heart?
  - "They are **darkened in…understanding**, **alienated from the life of God**…**due to their hardness of heart; they have become callous**…" Ephesians 4:18-19
  - "Take care..lest there be in any of you **an evil, unbelieving heart, leading you to fall away from God**…Who were they that heard and yet were **rebellious**?" (Hebrews 3:12-13, 15)
  - A defense or coping mechanism; a place to hide, to shield us from hurts. A wall we build to protect us from hurt, but which make us lonely and miserable.

Heart of Stone:
How It Is Formed In Early Years

- "Sinful" response to our earliest experiences of rejection, frustration, unmet needs, dissatisfaction
  - In-utero: A mother was entertaining the thought of abortion or having the child adopted. The baby in the womb senses this and feels unwanted. An expecting couple wants a boy but the baby in the womb is a girl. The baby feels rejection and afraid to reveal herself knowing parents will be disappointed
  - Crib experience: baby cries wanting the mother's breast, but instead gets a change of diaper. Or baby cries because of soiled diaper but is given milk instead. Baby is frustrated but can't speak.
- Inability to process good or bad, right or wrong, and not knowing how to forgive creates in the child a disposition to hardening of heart.

Heart of Stone: How It Is Formed In Later Years

- From physical and emotional hurts: betrayal, rejection, broken relationships; Unforgiveness
  - **CCC 2840**: …In refusing to forgive our brothers and sisters, our hearts are closed off and their hardness of heart makes them impenetrable to the Father's merciful love; however, in confessing our sins, our hearts are opened to his grace.
- Unrepented and habitual sins, which leads to rebellion against God
  - "He stiffened his neck and hardened his heart against turning to the Lord, the God of Israel." (Referring to King Zedekiah, 2 Chronicles 36:13b)

General Rule Heart of Stone

- We all form hard hearts
- Love, laughter and prayer in the family can soften the hardened heart
- Where these are missing, the heart will harden quickly and become closed off
- In Christians, it is often hidden; found in a loving, serving believer who can minister, but can not be ministered to

Impacts of Heart of Stone

- On self:
  - Loneliness and isolation
  - Can't hear rebuke or warnings
  - Inability to serve/be ministered to
- On others:
  - Refuses love and intimacy in families
  - Disparages or belittles the gifts of others
  - Destroys community spirit

Healing the Heart of Stone

- Recognition
  - Psalm 51: 5 – "For I know my transgressions; my sin is always before me."
  - Help the person understand how his heart got hardened. Usually difficult for him to see his hardened heart, to be vulnerable and to open up.

Healing the Heart of Stone

- Confession & Repentance
  - Psalm 32:5 – "Then I declared my sin to you; my guilt I did not hide. I said 'I confess my transgression to the Lord, and you took away the guilt of my sin."
  - For sinful reactions to early experiences
  - For wounding others, wounding the heart of God
  - For destruction done in one's life

Healing the Heart of Stone

- Forgiveness
  - Of self and others
  - CCC 2843: …" It is…"in the depths of the heart," that everything is bound and loosed. It is not in our power not to feel or to forget an offense; but the heart that offers itself to the Holy Spirit turns injury into compassion and purifies the memory in transforming the hurt into intercession."

Healing the Heart of Stone

- Prayer
  - Psalm 147:3 "The Lord…heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."
  - Prayer is done with others and not by the counselee alone. The walls we have built around our heart keep us isolated and hidden from others. We must encourage the hardened heart to take the risk of revealing ourselves to others and be vulnerable. Encourage them to participate in community fellowship.
  - Pray for death and resurrection and for basic trust
  - Speak prayers over and over again to reach the inner child

Healing the Heart of Stone

- Support
  - Give and ask for holy hugs. Remember that love overcomes a multitude of hurts and sins
  - Ask the person to learn to be seen and known by others
    - Participate in a community ministry where gifts and talents may be used for God's glory
    - Find friends who will tell the truth, and listen to them
    - Share with spouse or a trusted person daily struggles as well as victories
    - Encourage to active prayer life and frequent participation in the Eucharist and Reconciliation

Scripture Foundation
Inner Vows

"Again, you have heard that it was said to your ancestors, 'Do not take a false oath, but make good to the Lord all that you vow.' But I say to you, do not swear at all; not by heaven, for it is God's throne; nor by the earth, for it is his footstool; nor by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the great King. *Do not swear by your head, for you cannot make a single hair white or black. Let your 'Yes' be 'Yes', and your 'No' mean 'No.' Anything more is from the evil one."* Matthew 5:33-37

Inner Vows
Outgrowths of A Heart of Stone

- Determinations or directives made by the mind and heart early in life. They are powerful
  - Obstructions in our nature, whose function is to hold us to feel, think and act only as they instruct
  - They may even have the power to obstruct our physical development
- As we are hurt, our first reaction would be to judge the one who hurt us and then make an inner vow.
  - Example: A person whose trust was betrayed by a friend. Judgment: My friend is not trustworthy. Inner vow: I will not trust anyone.
- Made early in life and forgotten; **our actions and reactions to hurt become automatic**

"Good" Inner Vows

- Some inner vows may seem positive, even desirable
  - "I'll be gentle to women, like my Dad"
  - "I'll never drink or smoke"
- But even "good" inner vows can be harmful
  - They coerce us to fleshly striving and self-righteousness
  - James 4:13-15 "Come now, you who say, 'Today or tomorrow we will go into such and such a town and spend a year there and trade and get gain; whereas you do not know about tomorrow. What is your life? For you are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes. Instead, you ought to say, "If the Lord wills, we shall live and we shall do this or that."

Traits of Inner Vows

- They are common to every individual
- They are powerful
- They are self-fulfilling (until broken)
- They are difficult to identify (unless evident in our behavior
- They refuse to change
- They don't disappear even during the maturation process
- They take on a life of its own
- They persist in producing negative fruit even after judgments are healed

Inner Vows
Negative Fruits

- James 5:12 But above all, my brothers, do not swear, either by heaven or by earth or with any other oath…. so that you may not incur condemnation.
- Automatic angers
- Bitter root expectancies
- Actions & words that trigger automatic reactions
- Anxieties & fears
- When we judge another and vow never to do what they did, the inner vow works in reverse:
  - "Therefore, you are without excuse, every one of you who passes judgment. For by the standard by which you judge another you condemn yourself, since you, the judge, do the very same things." Romans 2:1

Inner Vows
Examples

I will always…

- Be a good provider
- Excel
- Responsible
- Remain aloof, separate
- Be logical
- Be in control of my life
- Be strong
- Be a good parent

I will never…

- Trust anyone
- Allow anyone to touch me
- Allow myself to be in need of...
- Let them take anything away from me
- Be weak
- Share what is mine
- Be violent or abusive

How to Break Inner Vows

- Recognition- Ask the Holy Spirit to help us recall our hurts, the judgments made because of the hurts, and the inner vows made as a response to the hurts
- Recalling inner vows is helpful but is not necessary
  - When we see a pattern of behavior or negative fruits and effects on our counselee/lamb, we have to help them realize that these are signs of inner vows, remembered or forgotten
- Forgiveness- We are able to break inner vows by forgiveness. Ask Jesus to grant us the grace to forgive others and forgive ourselves, and to seek God's forgiveness for our sinful responses to hurts

How to Break Inner Vows

- Confession & Repentance
  - Go to the Sacrament of Reconciliation
  - James 5:16: "Confess your sins to one another…"
- Renouncing the vow- can be broken only by the authority given by Jesus Christ
  - Matthew 16:19 *"I will give you the keys to the kingdom of heaven. Whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven; and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven."*
- Patience & Perseverance- overcome bad habits/hate evil
  - Ephesians 3:16 – "That he may grant you in accord with the riches of his glory to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in the inner self."

Sample Prayers

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SAMPLE PRAYER FOR BITTER ROOTS

PERSON RECEIVING PRAYER:

Lord, I recognize I have judged _____ for _____ and have locked myself into the same behavior/attitude. I choose to forgive him for hurting me, and I choose to release my right to hold this offense against him, knowing it is up to You alone to judge all of us. Please forgive me for the sinful ways I've reacted and for the ways in which I have done the very same to others (be specific in naming those you've hurt and how). I put these sinful practices to death on the Cross. Please cleanse me with your precious blood and give me a new heart. In Jesus' Name, I pray, Amen.

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SAMPLE PRAYER FOR BITTER ROOTS

PRAYER COUNSELOR:

As a servant of Jesus Christ, I say to you that as you have forgiven those who wounded you, so also has the Lord forgiven you. Lord, I ask You break each judgment that has been named and remove it from _____'s life. I ask You to consume the reaping of all the years of sowing destruction. Replace it with Your blessings. And I ask You to bring experiences into _____'s life as evidence these judgments are no longer operating. Strengthen in him the inner man to be able to practice new responses. And continue to bring awareness of any other judgments in the perfection of Your timing. In Jesus' Name, Amen.

Prayer for a Heart of Flesh

Father God, take away my hardened heart and grant me a heart of flesh that is always open and welcoming to you. Purify and sanctify my heart. Build it into a holy temple, a dwelling place filled with your Spirit of Love.

O Jesus, you who are the perfection of beauty, goodness and holiness, and the refulgence of God's glory. Seal my heart with the imprint of your being and surround it with your divine mercy. Reign in my heart, O Lord!

In you, my heart is glad, and my soul rejoices; my body dwells secure. Thank you for showing me the path of life. In your presence is fulness of joy.

Prayer for a Heart of Flesh

Lord, I have developed a defense to keep myself from being seen. I have built a hiding place to protect myself from hurt. I know that this "protection" blocks out the love, warmth and nurture I long for. I come to You because I am helpless to change. Come into my life to take down the wall. You alone are my refuge, my strength, my only defense. Lord, help me to become vulnerable, to risk love, even if it could be refused or rejected.

Lord, I forgive those people who have wounded me, and I forgive You, Lord, for allowing these wounds in my life. I also forgive myself, for my sinful reactions to hurt, and for building this heart of stone.

Prayer for a Heart of Flesh

Father, forgive me for my sinful responses, for the way in which I have hurt loved ones by keeping them out of my life. I repent for the destruction in my own life, and for wounding You with my sin, Lord.

Lord, as an act of will, I choose to be connected to others within my family and the Body of Christ. I want to be intimate. Forgive me, Jesus, for not trusting the love offered me by my spouse, children and fellow Christians.

Help me to see and appreciate the gifts of others. Put a watch on my lips that I may build up instead of tear down. Help me hear the warnings or rebukes as love and not as rejection. Help me to hold myself in the vulnerable position of receiving ministry, not just offering it. I ask You to bring people into my life who know how to love unconditionally and still have the courage to hold me accountable. Bring to death my heart of stone, and give me a heart of flesh.

Prayer to Break An Inner Vow

- Counselee: I renounce this vow_____. (name the inner vow)
- Counselor: By the power and authority of Jesus, I break this vow. I command your spirit and body to no longer remember it. You are free, restored to your original design. You are no longer required to feel, think and act according to this vow.

References

- Catechism of the Catholic Church
- Elijah House Christian Counseling